

FINDING SENSE IN THE NOW

A One-Act Play

By Rebecca Llopis

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CHARACTERS

REBECCA

Woman. Early 20s.

SETTING

Everywhere.

TIME

Now.

SCENES

ACT 1

Scene 1 - Mind Full

Scene 2 - I am The Observer

Scene 3 - Smells Like Home

Scene 4 - Out of Touch With Reality

Scene 5 - Rebirth

S.C. PRESHOW play from the start [The Mad Man's Laughter](#)

ACT 1

SCENE 1 - MIND FULL

S.C. NO SOUND

LX LIGHTS UP

*Silent. Four black boxes are positioned in a square. Spotlight on **REBECCA**, sleeping, tossing and turning, wakes up. Paces up and down center stage, in her head, on the verge of falling down a black mental hole. Recomposes herself. Shakes her head. Finds a spot centre stage, sitting cross-legged in lotus position. Beat. Deep inhale 1,2,3. Exhale 1,2,3.*

REBECCA

I don't like the silence. Waking up in the dead of night. Alone. Free-falling into the abyss of my own thoughts. This gloomy feeling takes hold of me. My life becomes just a memory. Abandoned. Dead. Floating into the endless universe, among the stars and black holes. Forgotten. Impermanent. Returning to dust. Panic rises again. Breathes. Interacts with the surroundings.
I see a black floor, rows and rows of chairs, people...
I smell...I don't know...nothing.
I taste... toothpaste.
I hear the buzzing sound of the air conditioning and...
A faraway police siren.
Inhales deeply. Voice breaks.
I feel. I feel... I feel ...scared

SCENE 2 - I AM THE OBSERVER

S.C. [Khruangbin - August 10](#) from the start

*Blocks in the four corners of the stage, like in a café. **REBECCA** on one upstage right waiting to order. She is observing the different "characters" in the room. Quick bursts. Playful but sharp.*

REBECCA

Looks at the audience breaking the fourth wall.

I love observing people. I don't know if it's the anthropologist in me, but it is fascinating to dissect their quirks and mannerisms, all that makes us humans unique. Maybe it's my artistic imagination, taking someone and projecting their whole past, present and future. Watching them smile, watching them stare out into the distance. Who are they thinking about? What is bringing them so much joy? Where are they heading? What are they leaving behind?

Cafés are the perfect spot to people-watch. Especially in Paris during l'apéro, where you can immerse yourself in "la joie de vivre" that the French are so renowned for. You see individuals from all walks of life. The third space, open to everyone and anyone.

Looks up, speaking in a polite customer voice.

"Bonsoir, je vais vous prendre un verre de vin blanc, oui un Chardonnay, s'il vous plait."

Slides to a new block, different physicality - loose body, slouched shoulders, knees splayed wide. Tapping foot. Laptop perched casually, one hand dangling lazily over a straw. Drawl in the voice, a little smug.

Take a look at that guy- his shoelaces are undone, he's wearing baggy jeans, sitting slouched, picking his nose.

Shifts into character physicality and voice.

Stickers all over his laptop saying "Sauve la planet!" "Climate Now", whilst he slurps from a plastic straw and throws his cigarette butt on the ground. Hypocrite, but kind of lovable.

Switches to other block- spine rod-straight, chest lifted, tight jaw, hands folded in lap. Lips pursed, tone clipped, precise, controlled.

On the opposite side is a woman.

Shifts into character physicality and voice.

Spine so straight it could snap. Bun so tight it's holding her skull together. But her eyes are darting, restless.

She's waiting for someone, maybe a secret lover, a getaway...

Shifts again. Old man- spine curved forward, shoulders rounded, hands tremble lightly, movements are slow, deliberate, and almost cautious.

And at the back of the terrace, under the heater in his usual spot, sits an old man.

Shifts into character physicality and voice.

Back curved, hands trembling as they cradle the check. Eyes cloudy, lost in a lifetime of memories. A loyal customer for over 20 years, the staff treat him like family.

Beat. REBECCA leans back, exhales. Returns to her natural composure. The glass of wine is served. She brightens.

Merci.

Smiles blissfully. Twirls her wine, takes a sip. Thoughtful.

Sometimes I wonder- When people look at me...what do they see?

S.C. Khruangbin - August 10 fades out.

A tiny, sly smile curls. She sips again. Lights fade.

SCENE 3 - IT SMELLS LIKE HOME

S.C. Orange Morning by Karim Azedia fades in

REBECCA stacks two black boxes on top of one another, and a third on the right downstage centre, like a kitchen counter. Light an incense. She pauses and looks at the audience.

REBECCA

Let me set something clear. I cannot cook for my life. But-my aunt Agnes- she is the best chef you will ever meet. She moved to Morocco 25 years ago and now lives in Casablanca with her four children- Ouweys, Abdallah,

Imrane and Selma. I have vivid memories of us laughing in the kitchen as we cooked our way through the hustle and bustle of life, stained head to toe with all types of sauces.

Puts on an apron and embodies Agnes, speaking in an Arabic-French accent.

Alors...

Takes an audience member on stage as if it were

REBECCA, *pantomiming as she teaches them how to cook.*

Tagine djaa-j- au poulet. "Donc pour une famille, we are going to take a nice chicken. Right there. We will use, what do you say...citron... lemon. A garlic, a big onion, a bouquet of parsley et coriander et a handful of green olives. Spices we will need curcumin, ginger, saffron, and salt and pepper. Clean the chicken. If you want you can take off the skin or you leave it. Cut very thin slices of onion... Add huile d'olive, and mix everything with your hands. Put the chicken in the sauce, make sure you mix well between the skin and the chicken. Some people leave the chicken overnight, and we say the chicken kesharb, which means it is drowned in the sauce. Then, on a low heat, leave the chicken to cook. Un delice.

*Accompanies the audience member offstage and returns centre stage as **REBECCA**.*

And that's as much of my aunt's recipe I will disclose.

Pause. Leans in, nostrils flare, eyes closed, savouring a memory. She breathes words out as if they're scents themselves.

But that smell. I feel like Ratatouille, you know, when he is overtaken by his senses and enters a flow state.

S.C. Camille, Michael Giacchino - Le Festin (From "Ratatouille")
plays from 0:20

Just him and the ingredients against the world.

Circles around the kitchen counter, throwing ingredients dancing away.

Onions melting into sweetness. Green olives baking in their saltiness. The chicken becoming tender by the second as its skin crackles and crisps.

She stirs faster, then slows- letting the scent settle in the air.

Garlic, sharp at first, but tamed by the heat. The curcumin cuts through the heaviness. And then...

Lifts an invisible lemon, squeezes, hand gesture, delicate.

The zesty smell of the lemon.

Beat. She sighs, and her body softens. She leans over the imaginary pan, eyes fluttering closed as she inhales. Daydream. Abruptly snaps out.

S.C. Camille, Michael Giacchino - Le Festin (From "Ratatouille") snaps out

The power of smell.

S.C. Arabian Night by Karim Azedia

Saffron, parsley, coriander, onion, lemon-

They're not just ingredients.

They are building blocks for the imagination.

They are a reminder of my aunt's voice as she guides my movements.

The way she laughs when I mess up-

How she glides through the recipe with effortless serenity.

It is the smell of her home... even when I'm oceans away.

Inhale. Smiles.

S.C. Arabian Night fades out

SCENE 4 - OUT OF TOUCH

S.C. Become Ocean by Seattle Symphony plays from 4:30

REBECCA *moves black boxes away from each other, spaced apart. Places one centre stage right and sits one leg over each side as if on a surfboard, scanning the horizon upstage. Looks over her shoulder back to the audience.*

REBECCA

You have to wait for the right one. Just you and the endless ocean. Looking over into the horizon where the sky fuses with the sea. It feels magical. Freeing.

REBECCA *plays with the water beside her.*

I love dragging my hands through the water and feeling the gentle pressure of the waves. Looking at the white sand down below, as it sways back and forth to the ocean's heartbeat.

My friend shouts, "Paddle, paddle".

REBECCA *turns her body around, facing the beach (audience).*

It's on. I throw my body down-Paddling- Arms burning- The wave starts to grab me- And I push myself up- hands gripping my surfboard.

Rises shakily on the black box, balancing, trembling. Proudly states.

I'm stan- I nosedive into the wave.

Underwater- *Struggling for her breath.*

everything flips- white foam. I've let go of my surfboard. My leash wraps around my throat.

Grabs at her neck. Lighting flickers like water distortion. Waves roar.

The wave drags me down- my board yanks me up-

Long pause. Struggling.

I leave my fate in the hands of the ocean... pulled right, tugged left, and finally floating up to the surface.

Takes a big inhale. Laughs out in disbelief. Recovering her breath.

It's the most alive I've ever felt. Terror, thrill. The fragility between life and death. All squeezed into one crashing second.

S.C. Become Ocean *slow fade out*

SCENE 5 - REBIRTH

S.C. *silence*

REBECCA *walks unhurriedly; she is peaceful, a smile on her face. She places the blocks around the room.*

REBECCA

Silence. REBECCA stands centre stage.

When I'm lost in my thoughts, heart racing, short breaths, I think of these moments. These overlapping memories that quietly weave into the tapestry of my life.

And I look around and find the serene beauty in just being here. Right here.

I find harmony in the small joys of life. Like the rush of serotonin when you meet a stranger with whom you get on like two peas in a pod, or the smell of your grandmother's tarte de pomme baking in the oven, or the feeling of giving in to nature's will, as you get lulled by the ocean waves.

Beat.

Silence. Close my eyes and take a deep breath in.

S.C. Give 5 seconds before fading in [The Mad Man's Laughter](#)

Do you hear that, the music, the gentle melodic strokes on the piano...

Listen. Really listen.

A blissful smile creeps across her face. Exhales. Sits still as lights fade out.

S.C. [The Mad Man's Laughter](#) fades out at 0:49

LX BLACKOUT

The End.